

Backpropagation in a Single Neuron - Episode 1

Milan Stanarevic

April 22, 2026

Backpropagation - Prerequisites

We will need few math elements / concepts (High School Level)

- ▶ Simple and Complex function Derivative
- ▶ Substitution / Chain Rule Derivative
- ▶ And two other things I will not mention here (comes later)

Backpropagation - Refresher - Simple and Complex function Derivative

We will not delve in the definition of Derivative, that does hold our interest and does not bring us closer to our goal.

► Simple function derivative

$$f(x) = x^3 \Rightarrow \frac{d(x^3)}{dx} = 3x^2 \quad (1)$$

$$f(x) = 5x + N \Rightarrow \frac{d(5x + N)}{dx} = 5 \quad (2)$$

Backpropagation - Refresher - Simple and Complex function Derivative

► Complex function derivative and Chain Rule

$$f(x) = (\ln(x) + \sin(x))^3 \quad (3)$$

$$u = \ln(x) + \sin(x) \quad (4)$$

$$f(u) = u^3 \quad (5)$$

$$\frac{\partial f(x)}{\partial x} = \frac{\partial f(u)}{\partial u} \frac{\partial u}{\partial x} \quad (6)$$

$$\frac{\partial f(x)}{\partial x} = 3u^2 * \left(\frac{1}{x} - \cos(x)\right) \quad (7)$$

$$\frac{\partial f(x)}{\partial x} = 3(\ln(x) + \sin(x))^2 * \left(\frac{1}{x} - \cos(x)\right) \quad (8)$$

Backpropagation - Standard Neuron Model

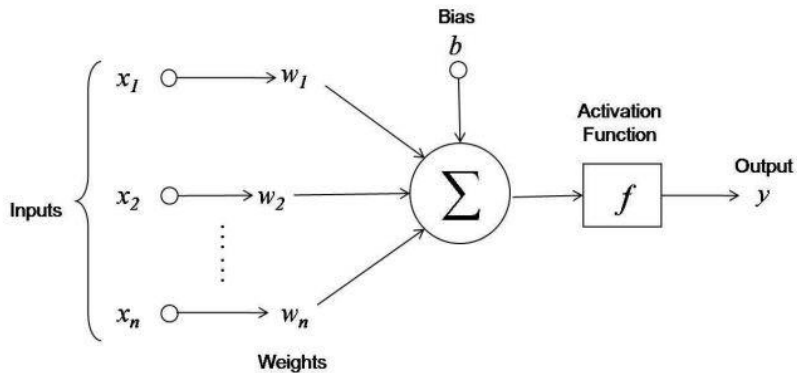


Figure: Standard Neuron Model

Backpropagation - Weighted Input and Activation Function

$$z : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \quad (9)$$

$$z = \sum_{i=1}^n x_i w_i \quad (10)$$

$$a : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \quad (11)$$

$$a = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-z}} \quad (12)$$

Backpropagation - Analytical Model & Problem

$$a(z(\bar{x})) \Rightarrow z \circ a \quad (13)$$

$$a = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-(x_1 w_1 + x_2 w_2 + x_3 w_3)}} \quad (14)$$

- ▶ Backpropagation is supervised algorithm.
- ▶ How to find w_i ?

Backpropagation - Model & Problem

Support structure:

- ▶ Measure of error / difference in output and target value.

$$C = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^n (T_i - a_i)^2 \quad (15)$$

- ▶ Using gradient descent:

$$w_{new} \leftarrow w_{old} - \eta \nabla C \quad (16)$$

- ▶ Where η is the learning rate
- ▶ Where ∇ is a vector differential operator

Backpropagation - Putting it all together

- Cost / Loss function

$$C = \frac{1}{2} \left(T - \frac{1}{1 + e^{-(x_1 w_1 + x_2 w_2 + x_3 w_3)}} \right)^2 \quad (17)$$

$$C = \frac{1}{2} \left(T - \frac{1}{1 + e^{-z}} \right)^2 \quad (18)$$

$$C = \frac{1}{2} (T - a)^2 \quad (19)$$

- Vector of differential operators

$$\nabla = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{\partial}{\partial x_1} \\ \frac{\partial}{\partial x_2} \\ \frac{\partial}{\partial x_3} \end{bmatrix} \quad \nabla C = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_1} \\ \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_2} \\ \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_3} \end{bmatrix}$$

Backpropagation - Putting it all together

► Partial derivatives

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_1} = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a} \frac{\partial a}{\partial z} \frac{\partial z}{\partial w_1} \quad (20)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_2} = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a} \frac{\partial a}{\partial z} \frac{\partial z}{\partial w_2} \quad (21)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_3} = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a} \frac{\partial a}{\partial z} \frac{\partial z}{\partial w_3} \quad (22)$$

► Common term

$$\delta = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a} \frac{\partial a}{\partial z} \quad (23)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_i} = \delta \frac{\partial z}{\partial w_i} \quad (24)$$

Backpropagation - Putting it all together

- ▶ Partial derivatives

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial a} = (a - T) \quad (25)$$

$$\frac{\partial a}{\partial z} = a(1 - a) \quad (26)$$

$$\frac{\partial z}{\partial w_i} = x_i \quad (27)$$

- ▶ Common term

$$\delta = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a} \frac{\partial a}{\partial z} \Rightarrow (a - T)a(1 - a) \quad (28)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_i} = \delta \frac{\partial z}{\partial w_i} \Rightarrow \delta x_i \quad (29)$$

Backpropagation - Putting it all together

- ▶ Vector of differential operators

$$\nabla C = \delta \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \\ x_3 \end{bmatrix}$$

- ▶ Gradient descent

$$w_{new} \leftarrow w_{old} - \eta \delta \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \\ x_3 \end{bmatrix} \quad (30)$$

Backpropagation - Putting it all together - Pseudocode

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network with focus on depth - Episode 2

Milan Stanarevic

April 22, 2026

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network: Agenda

- ▶ We already know how to backpropagate through a single neuron.
- ▶ We will learn how to backpropagate through a multi layer neuron network (no width, just depth).
- ▶ We already introduced all the necessary concepts and math elements in the previous episode.
 - ▶ Partial derivatives
 - ▶ Chain Rule
 - ▶ Gradient descent (SGD)
 - ▶ Cost / Loss function (MSE)
 - ▶ Vector of differential operators (nabla, η)

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network: Agenda

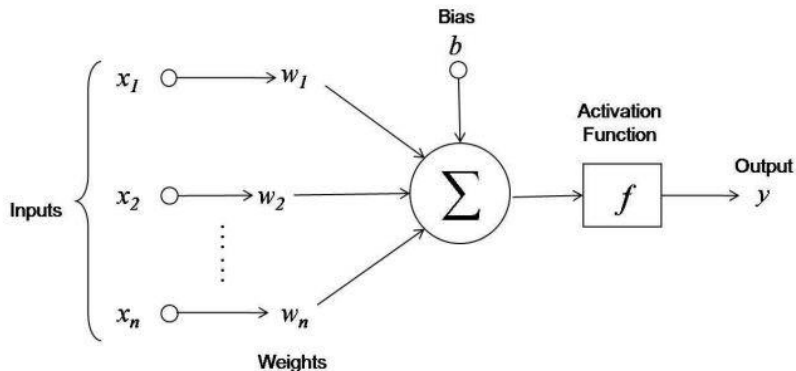


Figure: Standard Neuron Model

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network: Strategy

- ▶ Apply chain rule to find derivatives for each weight in the network, use MSE as a Loss function (no biases).
- ▶ Apply gradient descent to update the weights of the network.
- ▶ Feed forward to get the output of the network.
- ▶ Check if the output is close to the target value.
- ▶ If not, go back to step 1.

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network: Gradient Descent

- Derivative of the Cost function with respect to the weights

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_2} \quad (31)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_1} \quad (32)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{00}}, \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{01}}, \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{02}} \quad (33)$$

- Gradient descent

$$w_{new} \leftarrow w_{old} - \eta \nabla C \quad (34)$$

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network: Gradient Descent

► Gradient descent

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_2} = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a_2} \frac{\partial a_2}{\partial z_2} \frac{\partial z_2}{\partial w_2} \quad (35)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_1} = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a_2} \frac{\partial a_2}{\partial z_2} \frac{\partial z_2}{\partial a_1} \frac{\partial a_1}{\partial z_1} \frac{\partial z_1}{\partial w_1} \quad (36)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{00}} = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a_2} \frac{\partial a_2}{\partial z_2} \frac{\partial z_2}{\partial a_1} \frac{\partial a_1}{\partial z_1} \frac{\partial z_1}{\partial a_0} \frac{\partial a_0}{\partial z_0} \frac{\partial z_0}{\partial w_{00}} \quad (37)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{01}} = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a_2} \frac{\partial a_2}{\partial z_2} \frac{\partial z_2}{\partial a_1} \frac{\partial a_1}{\partial z_1} \frac{\partial z_1}{\partial a_0} \frac{\partial a_0}{\partial z_0} \frac{\partial z_0}{\partial w_{01}} \quad (38)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{02}} = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a_2} \frac{\partial a_2}{\partial z_2} \frac{\partial z_2}{\partial a_1} \frac{\partial a_1}{\partial z_1} \frac{\partial z_1}{\partial a_0} \frac{\partial a_0}{\partial z_0} \frac{\partial z_0}{\partial w_{02}} \quad (39)$$

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network: Gradient Descent

- Substitution with layer deltas

$$\delta_2 = \frac{\partial C}{\partial a_2} \frac{\partial a_2}{\partial z_2} \quad (40)$$

$$\delta_1 = \delta_2 \frac{\partial z_2}{\partial a_1} \frac{\partial a_1}{\partial z_1} \quad (41)$$

$$\delta_0 = \delta_1 \frac{\partial z_1}{\partial a_0} \frac{\partial a_0}{\partial z_0} \quad (42)$$

- Compact derivatives per layer

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_2} = \delta_2 \frac{\partial z_2}{\partial w_2} \quad (43)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_1} = \delta_1 \frac{\partial z_1}{\partial w_1} \quad (44)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{00}} = \delta_0 \frac{\partial z_0}{\partial w_{00}}, \quad \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{01}} = \delta_0 \frac{\partial z_0}{\partial w_{01}}, \quad \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{02}} = \delta_0 \frac{\partial z_0}{\partial w_{02}} \quad (45)$$

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network: Gradient Descent

- Replace each derivative with its equivalent form

$$\delta_2 = (a_2 - T)a_2(1 - a_2) \quad (46)$$

$$\delta_1 = \delta_2 w_2 a_1 (1 - a_1) \quad (47)$$

$$\delta_0 = \delta_1 w_1 a_0 (1 - a_0) \quad (48)$$

- Final gradients

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_2} = \delta_2 a_1 \quad (49)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_1} = \delta_1 a_0 \quad (50)$$

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{00}} = \delta_0 w_{00}, \quad \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{01}} = \delta_0 w_{01}, \quad \frac{\partial C}{\partial w_{02}} = \delta_0 w_{02} \quad (51)$$

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network: Gradient Descent

- ▶ Gradient descent update rule

$$w_{new} \leftarrow w_{old} - \eta \nabla C \quad (52)$$

- ▶ Apply to each weight

$$w_2 \leftarrow w_2 - \eta \delta_2 a_1 \quad (53)$$

$$w_1 \leftarrow w_1 - \eta \delta_1 a_0 \quad (54)$$

$$w_{00} \leftarrow w_{00} - \eta \delta_0 i_0, w_{01} \leftarrow w_{01} - \eta \delta_0 i_1, w_{02} \leftarrow w_{02} - \eta \delta_0 i_2 \quad (55)$$

Backpropagation in a Multi layer Neuron Network:

Pseudocode

```
error = infinity
(i0, i1, i2, T) = sample()
while error > epsilon:
    # run model once and keep intermediates for backprop
    (a0, a1, a2) = forward(i0, i1, i2, w00, w01, w02, w1, w2)

    # backpropagation (training focus)
    delta2 = (a2 - T) * a2 * (1 - a2)
    delta1 = delta2 * w2 * a1 * (1 - a1)
    delta0 = delta1 * w1 * a0 * (1 - a0)

    # gradient descent weight updates
    w2 = w2 - eta * delta2 * a1
    w1 = w1 - eta * delta1 * a0
    w00 = w00 - eta * delta0 * i0
    w01 = w01 - eta * delta0 * i1
    w02 = w02 - eta * delta0 * i2
```